Undesirable Beasts

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/64508452.

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Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Catra & Melog (She-Ra), Catra & Scorpia (She-Ra)

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Part 10 of Of the Blood, By the Blood

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Undesirable Beasts

by Nny11

Summary

The discovery of blood healing entailed the discovery of undesirable beasts, and reminds us of our adage.

We are born of the blood, made men by the blood, undone by the blood. Our eyes are yet to open. Fear the old blood.

Notes

Italics are Melog speaking inside Catra's mind, if you ever seen italics in quotation marks that's Melog speaking through Catra. Just a little demonic possession, don't worry about it!

Fear: Transformation

Chapter Summary

Catra wakes up, and so does Melog.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When she woke, the world was muffled.

Distant.

Cold.

Alone, supine, the world spun slowly around her as she tilted her head to look. A clinic. Her clinic. ***HER*** clinic.

Catra gasped. A weak, wet sucking sound as she heard distant bells before her vision cleared just enough to see it. A blood vial, needle already exposed. If she could just reach it- her body ached starting from her chest like fire. *In danger.* Yes, she was in danger, she needed to heal herself no matter the consequences, no matter the pain. The blood, she needed the blood!. *Let it sing to you, whisper its lullaby.* She reached and reached, fingers tapped a mere hands width away. Too far. Gods, it was just too far. Tears stung at her eyes as she stretched again. *Shhhh.* She would survive a whole childhood under Shadow Weaver, survive a fight with a true cleric beast, and to, what? Die here because Adora- **Adora**-

Pain. So much pain! *I can help!*

A liquid, no, yes, it- a mulberry colored muzzle pushed the vial to her. Or- or was it her to it? Hard to tell what it had touched; Sh'ra protect. *That is not my name.* Catra's body moved even as she lay still, a bloody trail glittered with stars before fading. A purr rolled into her chest as the needle plunged deep into her side. How, she

hadn't- *shh, just a little help*. It burned, white hot, somehow only adding to her pain. She knew better after a lifetime of experiments, there was no upper limit at which she'd ever lost consciousness. She'd just go mad this time. *Good.* Ha! Perhaps it was, perhaps she'd be lost forever this time, that sounded nice. Instead she endured.

Her head throbbed in the wake of it, her body no longer on the brink of death. She blinked and her arm fell limp as it returned fully to her control. Her vision cleared and the world froze as she was finally able to focus on what she could see. She stared at her hand, lifting it to her face as it trembled. Claws where her nails should be, fur bristled out from under her sleeve, the backs of her hands seemed skeletal, oddly elongated. No. *Yes.* "No!"

She'd- she'd had it under control! Catra swallowed hard, rolling like a drunkard to lurch upright. Head spinning with vertigo as she moved toward the stairs. *Calm.* No! *I can help, let me help.* She needed a mirror. She needed a gods damned mirror and there was only one full length mirror in this cursed place. *Why? You know what we are.* She needed to get her fucking head on straight! She needed to- she wasn't-

"No." Catra's denial rang hollow as she walked, the last of her own blood dripping from her limp finger tips leaving a trail of cherry drops behind her. Each step brought her closer to the betrayer's room. Adora's room. Adora, why had she, why had- *We were-*

The beast- no! The thing. The- the voice? Her voice! Her own gods damned voice- *Why deny the truth?* "SHUT UP!" It needed to be silent! Her chest and throat rumbled to life with a deep growl, dying out behind her clenched teeth and fangs as a sob caught in her throat. "Help me!" The gods had never answered her prayers before, there was no reason they should now either. *I want to help, I do, I do.* Catra stumbled over the rug as she crossed the threshold in her panic, turning up the gas lamp before she looked into the mirror. Fur and fangs and claws and beastial ears, a tail lashed behind her, and her eyes- half golden half blue, like the mark of a devil! As if that was her greatest concern. Ha! A beast!

Damned beasts all over the shop! She needed a mirror. This was a mirror. Her heart nearly ripped from her chest with terror. It wasn't her. That wasn't her. It couldn't be! Where was the mirror? Or- or where was her reflection then? Where was she? *It is us.* Something within soothed, the words like a gentle nip at her hands. *It is you.*

And it was.

The first sob came without warning, forcing her mouth open and the smells- this was Adora's room. This was Adora's scent. Adora was everywhere. The deep comfort, the love it normally brought now broken by the cold press of steel. Catra choked as she looked at the beast's chest in the mirror, a blood soaked shirt from the heart down, and the smallest tear over it. Her heart shuddered uncontrollably as she stared. *She'd meant to kill you.* "No." But this was no protest. It was a plea. To turn back time, to make Adora take it back, to make sense of it. She'd had it under control, until she didn't. And Adora...

She reached out to the dark one, she didn't even face you.

That was true. Her numb body shook with a wash of pure rage, her clothes felt tighter, painfully tight. That was true.

Adora had reached out to **Shadow Weaver** and not **to her**?! Begged the old witch to think or feel and return- but Catra had barely started to turn when she'd- she'd…

It does not seem fair. It wasn't fair. It wasn't fair at all, Adora had stabbed her literally in the fucking back without any pleas for Catra to come back. No begging for miserable little beasts. Like she didn't care. *Maybe she hadn't.* Maybe she'd **never** cared. Maybe she'd been grateful for a reason to dispose of her. Catra collapsed, her knees hit the floor violently as she keened and keeled over to lie on the floor. The beast followed suit in the mirror. The beast. Her. That was her. A harsh laugh barked out from behind watery whimper.

Weaver had been right. Of course. She was always right, even when she was wrong.

Catra giggled helplessly as fresh tears soaked into the hair newly grown on her face- gods, fur? Weaver was right all along. There had always been something wrong with her. Something broken and twisted and unloveable. *Adora didn't care.* Adora didn't love her, not like she'd loved her. After all, it turned out she truly was a wretched little beast, wasn't she?

Yes. No. Perhaps.

She squeezed her eyes tight as if that could make the world go away, and for one brilliant moment, it did.

Catra could see light behind her closed eyes, the world tilted again. She lay in the blackness of space, distant stars twinkled too far to provide comfort or light, and stared up in desperation. A human skull, far too large to be truly human, stared down at her. It's rictus grin stretching a hair too wide. A long flowing mane danced in the air, crackled with lightning as it swayed without a breeze. The fur on it's body was patchy, looked greasy and matted, hung far too loose from the clean white bones. The creature lowered its head to her, blood dripped from its nose, forming a face and then a snout before it dripped down towards her. But the blood never reached her. Vanishing like mist with each gentle plip plop, drip drop. The exposed bones in it's legs squealed and crunched as it crouched down beside her. And then the room came back. The floor shook as the beast dropped heavily next to her, curling around her. Paws, almost human-like in their shape, cradled her close to its chest. It was warm, and solid as it nuzzled her head. Slowly, oh so slowly, it began to shrink, to vanish and childishly Catra feared it was leaving her too. But instead she felt the warmth move inside of her, to her heart which began to pump steadily with its presence. Warmer and warmer as it brought her back from this too.

And then it was gone.

She glanced about, just in case it had moved but all she saw was the same horrible creature in the mirror.

It's us!

She wouldn't remember smashing the mirror, clawing the walls and the bed and the floors. When she came back to herself there were people speaking downstairs, strange moonlit scents. Hunters most likely. Time had passed, too much time had passed. Her clothes were cold and tacky with her blood, her belt felt heavy as something shifted on her hip. Her hands were wrapped haphazardly in bandages. How long had she- *Long. Not too long. We must go.* Catra crept silently on all fours, walking over glass and splintered wood to climb up the stairs to the very spot she'd stared out earlier that same day. *We should leave.* Yes. Yes, she should.

So she slipped out into the night, just one more beast.

Chapter End Notes

> Huge apologies to everyone for "killing off" Catra before. I legit hated that chapter so much because I thought it lacked all emotional punch and kind of forgot not everyone knew my plans. And then when I saw the impact I realized I shouldn't really go back on it considering I had tagged major character death.
>
> So, uh, yay for Catra surviving that? Semi-surviving that? Being forced back into the horrors of the world?

Shame

Chapter Summary

Catra lives, for what little that's worth.

Chapter Notes

Reminder that long italics are Melog talking to Catra in her mind and italics in quotes are Melog talking by using Catra's own throat and mouth.

She tried to finish what Adora began.

Gods, sh *e* tried to finish it.

Her new craving for violence, the enticing scent of blood, a restless need to hunt and fight. It was overwhelming and she wanted nothing to do with it. To not experience the downs that inevitably came regardless of the choice she made. She wanted to be done, and so, Catra had tried to finish it.

To fully transform. To be free of knowing what she'd become.

But life was cruel and unfair and cold, and she had never once been granted what she wanted.

So each day she skulked about, having returned to the orphanage once the church hunters had finally left along with Weaver's dissected remains, abandoned and feared by the few who had seen the ghastly fight through the wrought iron fence; although there were fewer of them each day until she felt she must be the only one left in the whole ward. But each night she left through the broken window to prowl the streets to make it stop; make the knowing stop. She was a beast, and so she wished to be only a beast. Beasts do not think, they do not reason, they do not hurt like this, those blessed mindless animals.

She craved it. The freedom.

But hunters had become few and far between with the constant infighting and the scourge's ever growing nature, so she did not seek them out. Instead she went by their example. After all, were all hunters not doomed to become blood drunken bastards? Beasts in all but body? And was Catra not just their inverse, beast in all but mind? Perhaps she just needed more blood. The blood was the key, after all, the discovery of blood ministration had doomed them all to such a fate. Catra just needed to speed the process along.

Yesssss, kill them. Just kill a few beasts, it will be good for you.

She feared the voice, the creature that lived inside her, even though it showed no desires of its own, what it whispered and growled and howled scared her. The reflection of herself magnified, She was like a small child again, scared of the distorted image of herself in the large surgery lights just before they turned on to blind her.

We are monsters, yes.

It's hopeless. It's so hopeless.

Ah, what's that smell? Blood…oh, the sweet blood!

Hate them! We hate them!

Oh it sings to us!

If we fall from that ledge, that would be enough. This one isn't high enough, but that one…

Or we could stop it easily too, a few quick swings of the blade.

We just need more blood. More. Blood.

She allowed it, did not question or fight it. Listening to convince herself of the necessity. Yet she still could not overcome her fear to try and attack any hunters. (*Stronger than us,* it whispered in her mind, muzzle curling in satisfaction with a deep rumbling purr,

but not for long.) And hunting them would only put her in more of their sights.

So she hunted her own ilk. Those with beastly bodies and addled minds, roaming in ever growing packs. Catra agreed with them, honestly would rather try to join them, but none would take her. She was, after all, welcomed nowhere.

Instead she fumbled with the threaded cane, still unused to its slender whip like function, backing up slowly enough to keep a few creatures following her while she experimented. Trying more force, less force, more wrist, more elbow, more shoulder. Twisting her body with the whip and planting her feet still. Some blows landed, some missed, but if she failed enough, Catra would change it back into a sword to slash and thrust away. It had been hard to pick it up, but once it rested in her palm it felt like it was always meant to. There was something to using that which had killed her to kill others, a bubbling resentment that she never heard the bells beckoning her to the great beyond again. Tonight was no different, and so she was left with nothing but time to experiment, to learn, to try and try and try-

You promised blood. The monster in her chest sulked.

"And," Catra grunted as she shoved a man back by his wooden shield, "you will get it."

It was almost like an overlay, she could see the scenario of a full transformation where she shredded through one and all with claws and teeth. It was distracting, more for the unintended cruelty. If she could do that, everything would be solved. She'd have no more fear, no more rage, just instinct forcing her along like these half humans she fought. But she was not a beast fully yet, and thus the world the creature inside her forced was nothing more than a fantasy.

Apparently unhappy with the reminder, her eternal guest somehow gave the impression of turning its back on her.

Catra relaxed her arm again, only using what was needed to swing the deadly blades about to shred most effectively. Tearing flesh and causing a near fountain of red to spurt out in tantalizing bursts. "See? Blood."

It is not the same.

No. She supposed it wasn't.

All the same she finished her work, stomping forward to check each body for anything useful. The blood on the ground called to her, their cooling flesh called too, both went ignored to the creature's chagrin. Her stomach growled and roiled at the same time with the memories.

Catra had tried, that first night, she'd taken a single bite of the flesh that had called too temptingly to her and tried to chew. Her jaw seemed to lock half open of its own volition, tears leaked from her eyes as she gagged, trying to force it down. Eventually she'd spat it out, having barely gnawed on it, and coughed until she'd throw up bile. She had managed to force herself to use their pooled blood to rinse her mouth of the phantom sensation, the voice inside promised it would help, but it had only made the situation worse. Then again, she hadn't understood yet that it only echoed what she had been desperate to believe.

But the flesh still made hunger gnaw at her ribs.

"Either help me or stop complaining." She hissed and the cravings slowly subsided, allowing her to continue on, whip transformed once more to a sword to hang from her hip.

She'd found a few vials of healing blood and reluctantly pocketed them herself, but not much else and her patience was wearing thin. The least her forced learning could do would be to help her survive. Survive.

Ha!

Gods, what a shit show.

There was no usable gun, no weapon that she liked more than Weaver's old cane. Only a few shining but worthless coins and occasionally a pebble she could throw away. Something had to be done. She was swiftly running out of food and a gun would allow her to at least try hunting animals in the forest. If she could find a way to the forest. It was all going so wrong so fast, and the gnawing hunger mixed with the cravings in a vicious cycle. It was enough to make a man sick!

"You there! Hunter! State your faction."

Catra froze, the half growl of frustration dying in her throat, before turning her head to listen closer. Her ears were bound to her skull with a rag, hidden under a sweat stained hat she'd found. Her tail stuffed down one of her trouser legs. Gloves and a half mask hid the rest. It was an inelegant disguise, but it served its purpose well enough. Give herself just enough room for a human to mistake her for something more than she could ever be again.

"And why should I?" She called back, slowly standing with hands raised to face the threat. A Force Captain. Of course it was the worst of all the options available, that was just her life.

"Because the Horde protects these streets. Who do you fight for?"

Catra couldn't help her snort of laughter, she really couldn't. "Protects these streets? Pray tell, why haven't I seen you moonlit bastards in the last two week?"

The woman puffed up with offense, giving Catra a better view from the moon and the torches. She was tall and broad, carrying an old fashioned boom hammer over her shoulders. But the robes were still pristine and Catra felt confident that of the two, she had more experience using her weapon in a fight. Ironic considering it had only been a few months at most since-

"Answer the question!" Ah. The woman hefted up her arm showing her hand cannon and quickly changed their dynamic.

Not much to be done against one of those except to explode without dignity.

"None. No one walked these streets so I stepped up." *We did not!* Catra rolled her eyes and mentally hissed back, *she doesn't know that.* "Are you taking over then?"

The woman slowly took a few steps forward, cannon still raised as a precaution. "Are you with that alliance?"

"Alliance?"

Sure, there were always rumors that various hunters or factions would join to become stronger. Allegedly the brilliant minds that used to fill their workshops had left but no new badges had appeared. At least not in this ward, perhaps the rumors had been true but meant for the rich and interloping outsiders only. They'd gotten the best of the blood healing too, only made sense they'd get the protection.

The woman huffed, but finally lowered her cannon so that was something at least. Her voice was mocking as she continued, "I guess not then. Tell me, that weapon, was it a gift from someone or did you just pick it off a corpse?" When Catra didn't answer she laughed. "Yeah, that's what I thought. Go home little girl. Leave the hunting to us professionals."

This was good, this was a good thing. Catra jerkily nodded and began to walk past the woman to leave. She should be content to leave, to know her current haunts were no longer safe, to live another day. This was good. Her heart raced, her throat tightened. The smell off the hunter was of soap and lye and polishing oils, a faint whiff of smoke and salt. Her fists clenched at her sides, teeth grinding as her frustration quickly boiled into a proper fury. This coddled bully, in clean clothes, well fed, human and accepted, dared to come here and demand what little Catra had left! *It's ours, it's* ***ours****.* It was! It was hers and now- gods, just walk! *Just go home, we should go home.* Her empty stomach twisted painfully and she stumbled as she passed the woman,

who laughed without turning to help. Her head throbbed and ears rang. She should go home.

Or-

But she was just-

- we can-

- so damn-

- *FEAST!*

- **angry.**

Catra had barely made it two strides past the woman before she went all in for a heavy thrust through her back. The thin sword was wrenched from her nerveless hand as the hunter collapsed to her knees in surprise, one of the woman's hands dropped towards her vial pack. *No.* It didn't matter how much the attack made her stomach turn (*we, of all people, are allowed!*), that could not be allowed. The hunter could not heal or else she would die, and unfortunately for her, tonight this beast felt no desire to die. No. This time, when Catra called to the beast it answered. Her glove was shredded like wet paper as her claws grew twice their size and sharpness. Her hand plunged easily into the woman's back and out again through her chest in a spray of hot blood. Shredding her heart and lungs as she ripped her hand back out with a squelch. Her heart sang, bells rang, tears pricked at her eyes with relief as she understood it was finally happening.

Sorry, so, so sorry.

The transformation did not finish though, her hand and claws shrinking once more as the hunter fell dead at her feet.

The world was silent except for her ragged breathing and the pleased purr of the beast inside her chest. The disgust only heightened her anger and Catra swayed dangerously, her ears

thundered in warning. She gasped for air, whole body tensing as if shocked by bolt paper.

"I can help! Rest, we are safe."

It was not the first time she'd grown so mad, so furiously mad, that she blacked out. The monster had told her twice before about it happening. But this time she woke not on the streets still prowling for prey, but back at the orphanage. The pristine leather pouches and belts the Captain had worn now hung from a hook on the wall, one bag bulged with vials she knew had not been there before, the signs of a long night of fruitful hunting. A simple hooded cloak was next to that, the once bright white was now hidden by uneven fresh gray ash. Disguised with the church markings ripped wholesale from the cloth.

"I have made food!"

Catra blinked down at the small fire in front of her, throat aching, and sure enough there was something bubbling away in a pot that would be forever ruined from its mistreatment. The soup smelled decent enough, and she could even identify what looked like vegetables in it. "What?" She croaked, fearful that her own voice would once more speak without her permission, only for the voice to once more come from inside herself.

The hunter had a little pouch, to eat on the go. I added the water!

Catra waited, watching inwards towards the beast, more fully than before. It's rippling body made of blood and bone was exposed, a tail swaying proudly behind it, looking like the most fucked up house cat she'd ever seen. Stars twinkled and it faded fully back into her, leaving nothing behind. No space behind her mind for her eyes on the inside to see. The city was quiet beyond the broken and ragged walls of her home. It waited patiently.

"...thank you?"

It purred deeply. *Eat. Stay strong.*

The voice, for the first time since she'd seen it in that world between worlds, she wondered what it truly was. *Melog, I am called Melog.* But what was it? She could almost feel its head tilt in confusion, the line of thought too blurred or too complex for it perhaps. *I am you. We are us. I am Melog.* Perhaps it was better to not know, to not understand at all. She had done nothing but fumble through survival so far, why not this as well? Hells, Melog had done better helping her survive than she had at this rate.

Gods. What had she been **thinking**?

Survival. She shouldn't want that! That- that hunter could have been the end of it. A quick death, nearly painless if she'd goaded the hunter into using the cannon. *No, no need to die again.* Catra stared into the fire as it whispered soft to her again, sad and solemn and promising. *Hunt more tomorrow. More blood. More please!*

More blood. Yes. She could at least manage that, one way or another.

Acceptance: Chimeras

Chapter Summary

Catra discovers the Research Hall and a new kind of beast.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra's life had become a living hell. It had never been pleasant before, but she could now definitively say it had gotten worse.

She had barely managed to find enough food and clean water or tonic to survive. She had taken so much blood healing that the pain had become more a hindrance than a terror. The creature inside had only been able to mirror herself, and as she had become sullen and lost, so had it. Sometimes she had dreamed that Double Trouble would return and finish her off; sometimes she had feared that Adora would. It had been mindless and endless work to hunt, as if each beast she struck down simply reformed the next day to be hunted again. Central Etheria had grown thin, its few remaining people trapped and addicted, and their desperation had made them dangerous enough to be deadly.

At least a dozen times, a gaggle of locals had chased her down, trying to hunt her. Twice, the foreigners pressed into service had cornered her. No one had come as close as the Force Captain she had killed… when had it been? It still felt fresh in her mind, but time had been slipping, and her blackouts had become more common.

Catra had not asked the creature what it did when it puppeted her about. The fact that she still lived implied more about the bodies than she wanted to know. Each night, they had sung to her without voice, cared for her more deeply than she was sure anyone ever had. The best part about them had been that she could see into them in a way like they saw into her. *We are one. No, we aren't,* she had chided gently, as it had grumbled back.

They were not one, but they had been as close as one could be to such a fate. They hadn't known any more than she had if her acceptance of it would help at all.

And the night was no different. Until it was.

She had sat on the orphanage roof. After the fight had destroyed the clinic, the few people who had stayed due to feeling some sense of safety from it had left. There had been no harm to fear up there as she once had. In fact, that night, she had felt almost nostalgic for her first night out on the hunt. The terror, the fear, the desire to live. The beasts were no less formidable now, but she had grown from the killings. She could now understand her one-time companion's flippancy as they'd wandered towards any entrance Catra could remember. It hadn't been that there was no caution, but the fear had dulled enough. She had sat looking out toward the forest, puzzling out a possible route to it out of boredom when she had felt it.

First a physical near-push from the air, then a loud bang as all hell had broken loose.

Catra had jumped and twirled to face it. The Healing Horde's tallest tower, and all that surrounded it was pouring smoke. And seconds later, shrapnel from it had rained down across all of Etheria.

"What in the world…" she had stared as the smoke had grew thicker and thicker, her fur lifting far enough to hurt. *Go see!* She wanted to, but would it be wise? *Do you care?* Catra had laughed bitterly at that. No. She supposed she didn't.

All the same, she crept slowly and quietly to the church, and when she had confirmed no one was fleeing, she had circled around the side. There was no such thing as too much caution around that many trained and armed hunters. But the Horde was truly gone. Even Lord Prime had not been spotted in… goodness, what? A year? Two years? Perhaps an experiment had gone wrong, she couldn't say when the Horde had vanished, perhaps

they'd left it running alone too long. *Perhaps it took them with it.* Hmm, no, where were the bodies then? *Snuck away like cowards!*

Her heart raced as she stared up at the tower. She'd been wrong. Not the tallest one— no, it had only looked that way from the ruins she still lived in. Large gates barred the way to the stretch of road where the smoke billowed out in acrid swirls. She had no interest in that, but here she could see something else, something of greater personal interest.

The Research Hall. Weaver used to terrify her with stories of it, of what Catra could expect if she was ever sent, and now it was destroyed. Weaver was gone, the hall abandoned, her home destroyed, and Ado-

We can look. Just a little look! Imagine what we might find?

She stared for a long time, waiting until her fear settled into a deep unnerving thrum, and then she walked forward; past where Hordesmen had once guarded the entrance with their lives. The doors opened smoothly at her touch.

The Research Hall had been everything Catra had feared it would be. Even in the aftermath of whatever had already torn through it, the destruction too close to not leave scars, it had been… gods protect, it had been horrible.

The patients were mostly slaughtered in their beds or starved to death on the floors, each one wearing a harness that buckled in the back to keep their arms pinned to their sides. Some even had more cords or belts around their legs, tightened until their blackened flesh spilled over the edges. None could be mistaken for human. Not anymore.

Melog purred in the back of her mind, half in their own pleasure and half from her own fear and discomfort.

Large, bulbous things. Like water filled sacks that undulated under her gaze. The skin stretched beyond recognition if not for the

occasional patch of hair or freckle or mole. It was all made worse by the fact that they were still alive. They still spoke. *Rip out their tongues. Shred them. Spare them.*

"I- I am sorry." The patient on a small rotted bed had spoken to her, their voice higher, more feminine than the last she passed. "I'm- you see, I'm better now. I won't do it again, I promise. I promise!"

Catra stood frozen over their bed, sword shaking in her hand as she stared down at their emaciated, mangled body.

"And I could send you there, you know." Shadow Weaver was drunk but at least tonight she was a happy drunk, for what little that was worth. "You think you have a difficult life now? Ha! You'd be strapped down tight to your bed up there, stewing in your own filth as they take and take or give and give. And- and! Eventually you'd end up like the rest too."

Catra clenched her jaw as she pulled uselessly at the thick leather straps keeping her on Weaver's table out of nervousness. It wasn't difficult for her to imagine the life of a patient. No. Not anymore.

Shadow Weaver pitched her voice into a pathetic, mewling imitation that Catra flushed with shame to hear. Her own cadence and voice thrown back in her face despite the slurring. "Oh Lady Weaver, OH Lady Weaver! Please, help me, Lady Weaver! Ha! HA! Wouldn't that be a sight, hmm? I might even go back to watch you squirm, child."

She dissolved into giggles as if it was the silliest, funniest joke she could conceive.

Catra's fingers felt numb with cold at the thought.

She had assumed it was exaggerated in some way. Minister Weaver always told a version of the truth, but rarely was she honest. What else had she promised that Catra would find to ring true?

“I am so very sorry,” the patient gasped and writhed, kicking their feet just enough to turn their dried excrement into a fine dust. “I’m guilty, I know it, but I- I’m better now! You can see it for yourself, I’m much better now. I won’t do it again, I p-promise, L-lady Wea-”

Catra gasped for air, choking on the ammonia and rot and decay as she stared at the pulsing head below her. Her sword sunk to the hilt into the patient’s throat cut off their words, but their skin still pulsated. A soft sloshing sound back and forth, back and forth, back and forth.

“ *It is for your own good,* ” Melog assured her, their control tenuous as Catra faded in and out. “ *Killing beasts is what hunters do, yes?* ” Was that what she was now? Unable to become a beast, had she become something worse? A hunter. Perhaps.

The patient’s fingers tapped incoherent patterns on the rails of their bed. It felt like they was trying to tell her something. If Catra listened close enough to the water and the tapping and the splashing, she was certain she could hear something of great importance. A soft sloshing sound and pitter patter like rain. Back and forth, and back and forth. It made her teeth ache and Melog pulled at her insistently.

It would be a mercy to kill them, right? Take responsibility for them (“*You can’t leave them here like this*. *You can’t take them with you*.”) (She can’t save them). But she could stop their suffering. “*You have the power.”*

She craved the feeling of flesh under her claws. Catra shivered, the desire and pleasure of feeling their soft little bones snap underhand and the warmth of their skin parting at her fingertips was so strong it was overwhelming. Yes, it would be a mercy to kill them but would she be doing it to be merciful? Her tail lashed behind her, her breathing picked up as she watched the faceless creature gasp again. Fresh blood, tainted black, leaked from their throat.

Melog hummed inside her head and her heart. " *You could take your time, really enjoy this. No one knows, no one will know, and you can't go any further can you? Eyes like little jellies to be popped and already all tied down.* "

It was a cruel thought, and it sang in her blood, they both growled or snarled or purred at the pull. "No."

" *Then you must end it quickly, shouldn't you? That would be merciful, it would be kind.* "

Yes. She should. A mercy, she reminds herself, this would be a mercy. How many nights had she prayed a hunter would find her tied and waiting under Weaver's ministrations? Yes. A mercy.

" *Finish the job.* "

She forced her hand to the side and down, slicing through side of the patient's throat. She didn't flinch as the blood spray covered her face, only stood up straight once more and removed her blade. Mercy. *Blood!* Catra would grant them mercy, any left alive.

She didn't wipe the blood away, it wouldn't make a difference, she'd become covered regardless.

Her brain itched and mouth watered and stomach turned as she worked, her sensitive ears and nose pinpointing each new patient that needed her help; the only help she could give. And each had a story she tried to forget.

"Splish, splash, splish, splash."

"Has someone, ANYONE, seen my- my eyes? I'm afraid I've dropped them in a puddle."

"I don't hear anything… please, take my hand, Lady Weaver. Please, help me, don't let me drown!"

"Do you hear the sound of water? How curiously the sea churns? Like- like a storm, but like a gentle rain. Waterfrom deep inside

me."

"Here it comes! Up through my insides, oh what rises from the depths, do you see, Lady Weaver? Ha! Oh, I can't wait!"

"Kill me. Please, just kill me. Free me from this place before I go mad!"

Catra dripped with blood, her fur matted and pulled painfully as her clothes stuck to her skin and the weight of them sagged down. It fell from her hands and it fell from her clothes a soft pitter patter like raindrops that she was sure sang true to the puddles she walked through. Water and bile and worse. Whoever had come through before to slaughter had either not been thorough or they had not cared in the least. They left the researchers and the ministers and the hunters dead, but left the rest to suffer, the ones who deserved it the least. And now she suffered with them as Weaver had always promised. And now- and now-

"H-hello? Is there someone out there? I can't see you, I'm afraid. Hello? Hello?"

Catra turned and marched herself towards the voice, refusing to lick the sticky blood from her hands. *Please, oh please, it would be so good!* No. No it would not. One more. Just one more patient to save, one more to show mercy.

How terrible that a beast like her was the only one with some damn kindness left in them.

"I, uh, I think I can hear you better now? Is someone out there? Can you- I know this is asking a lot, but can you please open the door? Please? I won't leave, I promise! T-the darkness is- it frightens me is all. Hello?"

The door wasn't locked, it creaked open as she pushed it, and she paused as she looked into the cell.

This patient had a normal head, an oddity among her peers. No sticky water or blood to plip, plop, plip, plop. Her whole body was wrapped in chains, more littered the floor around her in broken lines and swirls. She could almost be mistaken for a human, if not for her strange beasthood. No fur or fangs, so common on them. Instead the woman had red plates that gleamed under the soft light of the research hall. Claws, yes, but large pincers instead of what she had. Chained to the wall directly was a tail with a stinger, which jingled as the tail rattled inside.

"Oh, thank you!" The woman sighed with relief, slumping under the lighting. "Oh, thank you so much, you have no idea how… much- uhm. I-it means. A-ha! Good, uh, good hunt I take it?"

She was a beast who could speak. A beast who was aware of her surroundings. Cognizant. Just like-

Catra swayed, unsure if she wanted to get closer to her or run.

"Was that you? Earlier? There was a lot of screaming- not that you KILLED **everyone** , I wouldn't imply that! No! But, ah, was that you? Missus Hunter? Mister hunter? My, uh, my fellow hunter? Or maybe not *fellow* per say," The woman's eyes were pure black, but for a moment Catra thought she saw stars swirling inside of them. "Now that I can see a little better, and thank you again for that light, real life saver! You don't look like you're with the church."

Catra growled, she didn't mean to, but her claws flexed out and her chest rumbled with the very thought.

"O-oh." The woman deflated at the sound. "So this is it then? Ha. It's- it's not funny. Not really. But it's uhm, what's the word I'm looking for? Oh! Ironic. Yes! Quite- quite ironic, ha ha! Well, I always knew it would be like this, didn't I? Momma always warned me, she'd say Scorpia, hunters only become the hunted! It just felt right at the time though, you know? And, uhm, look I'm not trying to rush you but this is, wow, I am really starting to freak out here. So, if you could just… get it over with?"

" *She thinks you are a mindless beast.* "

Ah. That did make sense.

"Uhm!? I- well, yes? Hello? Can you understand me?"

Catra felt light and floating, barely in control. No. Perhaps not in control. Ha!

" *Yes, we understand you. She is in shock, I think.* "

"You think, ah." The woman's smile became somehow more strained as it stretched too wide across her face, curling literally up to touch her ears before she muttered clearly to herself, unaware of Catra's hearing, "Oh boy, this gets better and better, doesn't it?"

" *Yes, it does! We can free you. You are like us! We are not alone!* "

Catra swallowed hard and shook her head, Melog chuffed at her annoyance. It was true, they got the feelings from her. Still.

"Nope, not alone. Just look at us, two peas in a pod!"

And suddenly she snapped back into place. Catra was fully in control, Melog happily curled up to rest, and she knew who this woman was. She knew her.

"Are you the hunter that saved me?" Catra asked, carefully stepping into the cell before turning her hand lantern on to help cast more light. "You brought me to be healed. There was, uh, there was a lot of blood."

And, really, that description shouldn't have been enough, but Scorpia's brows shot to her hairline and her mouth dropped into a perfect shocked O.

"Oh, wow, pretty la- I- I mean the strong lady! Oh wow! I, uh, I didn't recognize you under all that- well! Were you being held

here and tortured with experimentation to try and make someone ascend into godhood as well???" Scorpia leaned forward, her tail pulled taut by the pressure. She didn't want to know that, she never had needed to know that.

"No." Catra felt something twitch along her jaw. "No. Too much blood I'm afraid, got me in the end. Just not… not fully. Or not right."

"Well, blessing for small things, yeah?" Scorpia tried to lean further forward only to wince and shuffle backwards on her knees. "Say, can you do me a HUGE favor and maybe help me out of this mess? N-not that there isn't great work being done here, but, uhm, I'd like to leave. Please."

It spoke to her own desperation for how quickly Catra moved forwards to inspect the chains. Two sets, one for her body and one for her tail, both locked with a single padlock. The tail chain was looped into a ring bolted to the wall, and the one around her body included many broken sections as well.

"Ha, yeah, I kept breaking them on accident, so the doctor went a tiny bit overboard with this set. And it is working like a charm! A-ha!"

Catra growled as her head throbbed with pain. *Tired, we are so, so tired* . Did she never shut up? "You always laugh when you're locked up in a hell hole, or what?"

"Ha!" Scorpia barked her laugh out and it sounded oddly genuine before the nervous edge came back. "Oh no, I'm just very scared right now and laughing is not really in my control at the moment!"

Yeah, more than she needed or cared to know. *We want to know, so alone, we've been so alone.* Catra grumbled as she wiped blood off the padlock that had dripped onto it from her hair. Pungent and sweet and salty and sticky. Melog purred deeply at it from inside her own chest.

"A-all good back there?" Scorpia asked with a giggle.

Catra shook her head and more blood splattered off as she did. “Sorry, bit distracting with two, uh-” What even was Melog? They declined to answer. “-people in here.”

“Nah, I gotcha, the cell is a bit small isn’t it?”

“No you idiot, I mean in- you know what? Be quiet, I need to focus so I don’t hurt you.”

Catra carefully lined her claws up, practiced the swing slowly a few times before pulling back and using her whole body to swing hard and fast. Her fingers stung and a prickling lighting went from their tips all the way up to her neck. Catra hissed at the pain but the lock was sliced open regardless and the chains were already starting to fall off of Scorpia’s body. She yelped and lept backwards into the cell wall as the other woman stood up quickly and flexed hard enough to make space.

Scorpia was huge. Monstrously large now in fact. Before she’d been maybe a head taller than Catra and certainly very muscled and fit. Now she towered easily over her, at least three heads taller and almost twice as wide as well. Her muscles stood out intensely and unnaturally, lacking the fat that a human would. Her at the end of her too long arms, her claws were larger than Catra’s thighs. Now freed, her tail snapped forwards a few times, a purple venom spraying from the tip.

And Catra was the idiot who just freed her. If Scorpia was mad, if she was blood crazed and hid it, if she-

“Oh, thank you!” Scorpia half sobbed with delight as she moved her body around before whirling and scooping Catra up into a hug that nearly broke bones. “Oh, thank you, bless you!”

Catra wheezed as she was dropped and automatically fumbled a blood vial to inject and heal the painful bruises.

“Whatever. See you around, I guess?”

Scorpia went from so joyful to terrified that it actually made Catra wince.

"Or, maybe, we could stick it out together? I mean, c'mon, look at us, two beastly hunters! You can't tell me we shouldn't!"

Absolutely not. *How could it work? Too dangerous for her.* "No. There's not even a place for me out there let alone two of us."

Scorpia wilted for a moment, before tapping her claws together with a bright smile. "But there is! There's an old workshop that's hidden, everyone's forgotten about it after Prime cut it off from the Horde. We could stay there, no beast has ever made it in, nor hunter since it was abandoned!"

"You can't promise that." Catra snarled, stalking out of the cell to get some air, only to be shadowed once more by Scorpia's hulking frame.

"This, I can. Not much more than that, but I **can** promise that."

Catra's ears rang and Melog grumbled more fully awake once more. Not a great sign honestly, but the idea of safety. Of a place to call home again? It made her weak. *I can help!*

When she blinked Catra realized she was crouched in front of a fire. Her fur and hair and clothes were damp but no longer heavy, the blood cleaned away. She slowly stood and looked around in a daze. A fireplace with a stone mantle, many blackened and rusted blades pushed into a corner, and quite a few bits of broken and charred furniture or wood. The roof miraculously had not fully burned, even if the bulk of the inside had. Half standing bookshelves and display cases without glass. Large piles of ash blown naturally by the wind into the deepest corners.

" *I helped. Time, you lost track of it.* "

How much had passed? They weren't sure.

“Oh, are you back? Sorry, that’s silly to say, isn’t it? Here’s that tea for you Wildcat! It’s a little on the heavy side, and I think I broke the only spoon left. Also some mugs. And a- you know what? Doesn’t matter, bowls work great and I’ll let you decide if it’s any good. Don’t want to shade your opinion or anything!”

Scorpia held out a steaming bowl that smelled horrible, smiling hopefully at her as Catra watched her hands reach out slowly and take it. And drink. It was bitter and awful, and the best thing about it was that she burned her mouth badly enough that she won’t taste anything for the next week. It’s the first kind thing someone has done for her in- since- *It’s perfect. It’s beautiful!*
“It’s fine. And my name is Catra.”

“Catra,” Scorpia whispered it like a prayer, her smile warm and sweet like honey. “It’s a wonderful name, suits you.”

And oh that is dangerous. That is very, very dangerous.

And Catra only craved more.

Chapter End Notes

> The Beastly Hunters finally meet and I bring my beloved Scorpia back, rejoice!

Mourning: The Forgotten

Chapter Summary

Spark Hunter Badge:

Badge crafted in secret by Archibald, the infamous eccentric of the Healing Church, for his friends.

Archibald was fascinated by the blue sparks that emanate from the hides of the darkbeasts, and dedicated his life to its artificial reproduction. in a style of inquiry that, incidentally, closely followed the methodology of Byrgenwerth.

She had never taken the church giants lightly. After all, it wasn't like one could be threatened with being eaten alive by them their whole childhood and not walk away with a healthy sense of trepidation.

Catra remembers back before Adora, back when Shadow Weaver had doted on her first little freak of nature, the way they would walk through the ward together. She would hold Weaver's burning hot hand as they walked from the orphanage across central Etheria, and then they'd pass over into the ward where so much magic was held and used that her finger tips would prickle with the cold. Back then, Weaver was more indulgent of her questions.

"Why does their feet look like that?" She'd asked, staring at the shining damp blue gray skin.

"Because they are not alive, child." Weaver had tugged her over to the nearest giant, who stared dumbly down at them.

She squinted for a moment at the bone exposed in its knee, something she'd never noticed at a distance with their fine, heavy robes. "Did they drown? They look kinda like it."

The one drowner she'd found had looked horrible. The year before, Catra had found one of their run away boys. He'd tried to

escape through the sewer system but had been stuck in the slender pipe instead. When the hunter had pulled the boy free, he had been a horrible bloated mess. His skin had turned black and purple and many water insects had feasted on him.

The giant's skin was bloated and slick, like it had stayed too long in a pipe itself. But the color was wrong, she supposed.

Shadow Weaver had laughed and then pulled their joined hands together to make her touch it. It was cold, but not slimy. It was a texture she would never forget.

Melog sniffed with disgust at the memory. Right.

Catra used her whole body to put enough force into her thrust. She'd learned to prefer the whip, but church giants and the various church servants seemed to die faster under the solid thin blade. The giant jerked awake as she pierced its back, she had already sliced it two more times before it staggered to its feet, two more violent stabs toppled the poor bastard before it had even fully risen. She didn't like the way they were so silent, mouths trapped open in a permanent scream from their very creation.

It collapsed to the ground, its tattered and stained robe snapped in the wind, and its chains rattled as its corpse finally settled.

Catra swiftly moved to check the few pockets on it, unwilling to still be nearby when it reanimated. She'd never seen them come back, no. But it was the only thing that made sense to her. The giants were stuffed full of magic, they were reanimated to begin with and simply returned in some fashion. It didn't explain the vials of blood they sometimes carried, nor the way they looked so much like the near identical servants.

"There is more of them than you can imagine."

"Not helping Melog."

"I am not trying to help. *I am merely telling you the truth."*

Adora had been the one to propose the idea that the giants were just servants of the church, but ones who had volunteered to die and be changed with the holy blood and magic into the giants. Eternal servitude. Catra hated her a little bit for it.

"She was right."

"And how do you know?' Catra quickly pocketed the two vials she'd found, running on all fours to the next one. She skipped to a halt and slowly, oh so slowly, walked behind the next giant to start the process again.

For a moment Catra could see in her mind's eyes a horrible smile. Full of fangs and blood and fire. A shiver ran up her spine at the memory of Melog's true form, another followed as they pushed hard enough to be separate in her mind.

"We are kin, they and I."

She threw her weight behind the thrust and ignored what she'd learned. So much of her life was managing her ever growing pile of boxes and coffins, keeping thoughts and feelings and truths locked away. Catra knew it wasn't healthy, but it did keep her sane and that was all she could care about as she sliced and stabbed until the giant fell.

"You are our kin too, of a sort."

Her heart clenched painfully at that. All of them, long since dead and bound in chains physical or otherwise. Forced into servitude. Catra may not have volunteered, but if Adora had only asked her? She would have. She would have done anything she'd asked. In the end there was no offer, but Catra transformed all the same. Her chains metaphorical perhaps, lightened since she stopped living in the ruins of her previous life, but tied she still was.

"You are unhappy."

"Be **silent** ."

"You are doing that thing, where you say one thing but feel another."

"I need to concentrate!" It was a weak lie, considering that was the last of the giants in the ward today. There would be more tomorrow, but for now that was it. Eight vials was almost not worth the effort she'd exerted, but they were life saving and the giants were slower and duller now that the Horde had lost full control over them. Mindlessly protecting against all, even those they were meant to protect.

"Catra-"

"I said be quiet!"

"Sorry!" Scorpia whispered so loudly the point was almost moot, Catra jumped regardless of her attempt.

"When the hell did you get here!?"

"Just a moment ago, I uh- sorry about the noise. I swear I just always trip over these guy's chains!"

She hadn't even heard that. Her heart pounded as she looked across the central yard and could see a wobbling line that Scorpia had practically cut through the dead. Gods, she was useless today. Just… worthless for much of anything. Perhaps that was a good thing, in the end.

"Nevermind. Did you find a way in?" Catra sheathed her blade, already turning to walk without look at her partner again. Scorpia either had and they'd be going the right direction, or she hadn't and they take a left and head home. It didn't matter. *Nothing really matters.*

"Yes! Come on, I'll show you, just past She-Ra's Chapel."

Catra snorted, Scorpia was the only person she'd even met who called Sh'ra that, but when she'd tried to correct her it had led to a long and rambling religious and historical explanation. Half the

information lost in Scorpia's memory as she did her damndest to convince Catra it was the original pronunciation. It felt too much like listening to Weaver's drunken rants for comfort and after she'd lashed out they'd both gone their own ways to cool off. Or, well, Catra went to cool off while Scorpia probably moped.

They went quickly and quietly by Sh'ra's Chapel, a dweller still lived there from what Catra had seen, enough incense to ward off beasts and the occasional glimpse of hunters that came and went. If the incense wouldn't have been deterrent enough with their sensitive noses, the hunters certainly were. The only reason they ever crossed paths with it was due to the entrance to their hideaway being technically inside of it, not that anyone went that way. The old church workshop was sealed and crumbling in the wake of the explosion, allowing them to slip down the homemade ladders and chains with ease. Dangerous, sure, but what wasn't dangerous these days?

Best not to think of it.

Catra rolled her head as they entered the abandoned Callosal Tomb and descended further, following along as Scorpia chittered and chatted. Letting the words wash meaninglessly over her as they made it finally to an oddly clear floor with a giant wooden door with something plastered over it. Scorpia held her torch up to it and Catra read:

This town is long abandoned. Hunters not wanted.

"This has to be it right?" Scorpia asked, free claw snapping open and closed without much thought. "The Swiddens, gods, if we could access it… reach Plumeria… "

Food, medicine, clothes, who knew what else. Relatively close to their base, mostly untouched in the last decade. Clean water supposedly flowed through from the moon lake, but Catra would bet good blood it was tainted with corpses and beasts. They'd split to make preparation easier once they'd decided where to go, Scorpia wanted nothing to do with the cathedral ward and Catra

needed to kill. She wondered if she'd have told Scorpia of the location of it if she'd been the one to find it.

You would've. I wouldn't. *It could have been ours alone! We don't need her!* I want her. *We need her!*

"Hey, if you aren't ready-"

Catra shoved forward and threw herself against the heavy door, ripping the warning in two. Through the doors they stepped out into one of the lowest exposed layers of the great city.

The Swiddens, once home to Etheria's farmlands, lay in smoldering ruin. Even so many years after the great fire it reeked of ash and smoke. The ward and all its towns had been closed near the start of the sickness, a precaution to try and stop the spread which had only led to their downfall. Every citizen fell to the scourge eventually and the density of the streets made it impossible to hunt the packs effectively, they would scurry into their passageways and hideyholes to vanish into the brittle grain fields like an army no one was willing to fight. The doors had been sealed, her people marked for death. The hope back then had been that it was the source of the beasts, of course the Horde had agreed with the assessment even as their blood supply continued to turn them all slowly. Plumeria had managed to survive its ward by sheer grit, feeding the city for several more years before falling silent as well.

The fields looked barren from this far away, and under the setting sun Catra could nearly see the flames sweep across them once again.

"Looks like this is the path," Scorpia whispered, motioning with her torch over a lone bridge. They moved in tandem towards it, only-

"YOU THERE, HUNTERS. …DIDN'T YOU SEE THE WARNING? TURN BACK AT ONCE."

They froze, looking to see the source of the booming voice. *Ah, clever.* Watching from somewhere, voice projected somehow, protecting themself from whoever might enter. *Yet pointless.*

"PLUMERIA IS NOW HOME ONLY TO BEASTS. THEY ARE OF NO HARM TO THOSE ABOVE. TURN BACK… OR THE HUNTER WILL FACE THE HUNT."

Catra almost felt more than heard her own sharp bark of laughter. As if they had not faced it and worse. When she'd hunted alone, she'd been hunted as well. Her and Scorpia combined made for too tempting of a target apparently, but the hunters who tried were either cowards or no match. All eventually parted around them and now all avoided them fully.

Scorpia smirked down at her with a chuckle, as if reading her mind they stepped forward again. This time managing to cross the bridge, slipping past a few beasts curled up on the ground, and even managed the next short bridge before the voice called again. Louder, the direction had to be from somewhere towards the old clock tower. Catra's ears twitched as she tried to pin point it further.

"I SEE, YOU ARE SKILLED HUNTERS, ADEPT, HALF-CUT WITH BLOOD AS ALL THE BEST ARE. WHICH IS WHY I MUST STOP YOU."

"What does that mean?" Scorpia huffed right as Catra heard something.

A click, click, click from the tower, something on top glinted as it moved. Something large and metallic. And then she saw a burst of fire, the kind she learned to fear from the muzzles of hunter's guns.

"Run!" Catra dashed, ignoring the beasts who jerked upright and alert as they passed, no longer able to care about the noise they made as bullets rained down on them. She couldn't understand it, was it several guns together then? What could even fire with that

sort of speed? *Down, inside!* "Jump, here!" Catra dropped down a full story, rolling to the side just in time as Scorpia landed heavily enough to crack the stone beneath her. From here they couldn't see the tower, but that only solved one of their problems.

"Wildcat!" Scorpia called, her tail striking out to smash a large beast away. Its bandaged arms could barely be seen from under the sheet on top of it, although its glowing red eyes certainly showed well enough as it screamed waking and drawing even more beasts.

Her blade was out, a flick transformed it and hit the creature in one fell swoop, the serrated edges doing wonders to make it bleed. Its focus moved to her just in time for scorpia to slam her claws onto its head in a powerful hammer swing. It screamed again, backing up and cowering against the wall, several beasts nearly jammed into the doorway arms lifted as if to guard their faces. Darting forward only to scuttle away again. A sea of glowing red eyes that easily swarmed them, yet none attacked fully.

Scorpia feinted and watched as one of them dodged towards her claw. *What is she doing?* Her claw clacked once, twice. The beasts slowly circling. Always attacking her right side. Why? Scorpia spun in a fast circle, sticking the torch out further and causing the beasts to rapidly dispersed. Catra watched them, too surprised to kill as they were spared. The beast against the wall, wailed pitifully, clutched at its head as Scorpia slowly walked towards it. Letting it snarl and even swipe as she corralled it into the corner of the small room.

"They're afraid of fire." Scorpia whispered, voice wavering with too many emotions.

"Good." Catra growled, receiving a snarl from the beast. With a roll of her eyes, she quickly grabbed her own torch and lit it off of Scorpia's. "Less fighting saves us supplies."

“Yeah.” Scorpia mumbled but snapped her mouth closed afterwards, following Catra as she sneaked her way further down.

Pity the poor bastards. Melog lamented, much to Catra’s shame. Her shoulders climbed to her ears and she hissed, “Plumerias warehouses were down by the old church, right?”

“...” Scorpia stared back into the gloom of the apartment they’d exited, before she answered slowly, “Yes, the Church of the Good Chalice. Hunters used to take communion there, you know? My mothers told me that most of the chalices lay hidden deep in the tomb of the gods, but this one we had retrieved to be worshiped and thanked. I- gosh I was so little- they brought me there once. I remember smelling the putrification for the first time, not much else though.”

Once. Gods be good they were risking it all on Scorpia’s memories long passed. But to admit such, to tell her about her own past- Catra hated the feeling it stirred in her. Spoke too quickly to think it through.

“M- my caretaker, Minister Weaver, she said she’d used the chalices inside the labyrinth. She lived inside the catacombs for years at a time back then.” And Catra had always believed it an exaggeration, but it was all she could think to say in the face of someone whose grief had been renewed so freshly.

Scorpia shivered in the humid evening air, her voice tight as she offered, “She must have been a remarkable woman.”

Melog snarled in her chest when the words left her feeling bare.

“ *She was worse than any beast.* ” Catra barely recognized her own voice, was grateful for their intervention.

Scorpia laughed, shoulders slumping with relief. “Yeah, don’t know many who liked her. Before or, well, after. Never saw something that looked quite like she did at the end.”

Melog asked in the space she left, " *You saw the cleric beast then?* "

"Cleric beast? No, no, she transformed into something else. Something much worse. But, ah, enough of that! We're here to get supplies, not dream of the past. Let's go, shall we?" Scorpia had no grace to it, but Catra didn't need any and Melog needed even less.

Their trip was mostly silent, only interrupted by the rattle of the gun above them when they strayed too far into the open or the shout of the beasts as they cowered from the fire. All too far gone for speech. The darker the sky became, the more fragile the dance became. The fire was needed to ward the beasts, but it drew the gun fire to them more quickly.

Her claws ached for blood. *Just a quick swipe. A short drink! So close, oh they're so close!* But killing one would only invite the others. She walked pressed fully against Scorpia's side, their torches in constant motion to keep themselves safe. The beasts darted in and out from the shadows, now so dark as to be indistinguishable from the night. A snap of teeth and howl of fear, the swish of the torches, the ache in her arm from the length of its use.

"Which way?" Catra asked, they stood precariously on a broken gate, backs to a wall to make it easier.

Scorpia squinted out into the night, the stars in her eyes swirled and her breathing caught in her throat. "I- I don't know, I can't tell now. I think… I think right?"

Catra growled, "You don't know!?" *Lies, she lied to us.*

"I was tiny," *it's all her fault,* "I don't remember the way and without a visual on the valley-" *Kill her.* "I'm sorry, Wildcat, I just don't know!"

Kill her. Now. Do it now. Kill her. Do it now. Now- kill! Kill! Kill HER! KILL HER! Blood!

Catra bit her tongue hard enough to bleed, choking as it blocked her throat. She spit it into the face of a beast as soon as it drew too close, it dripped down her chin, the mob became frenzied. "Wildcat!?" *Kill her- blood, more blood!* She needed to think. "Are you okay-" She needed- *So easy, so trusting, you want to, you want to-* She did.

And she didn't.

"Right it is!" Catra howled, charging ahead recklessly. Swallowing blood as she dodged claws and teeth. Her hand cramped, twitched, broke, grew, shrank, broke- There was something. Something at the tip of her tongue. The rage. Gods, the *rage* . Luven would be proud, he would be so, so proud. Luven? Who- gods but her head ached! What was wrong with her? Melog sobbed inside of her throat, " *So close now, we are so close!* "

"Catra! Wait- just- you are so fast!? Hang on a minute!"

But she couldn't. If she stopped she'd know, she'd understand, she'd remember, she'd kill and she'd kill and she'd kill and this time she would transform. Fully and truly. Or she would die. She'd craved either for so long, but now- *we don't want to die.* She threw her body against another set of wooden doors, these even larger than the last. This had to be it! A warehouse, or the church, or- or- it had to be something! Her brain itched as she heaved with all her might. Melog circled and circled and circled as something caught in her throat.

And then Scorpia slammed into the door next to her, adding to her attempt, the howling sounded further behind, the door yawned open just enough for them both to slide through. Then shut with a resounding thud as they barely managed to close it behind them. Both panting for air, shaking and dripping sweat.

Not one kill! Melog bemoaned, incredulous. *All those beasts, and not one kill.*

“O-okay. Let’s- let’s just take a break here.” Scorpia gasped, trying to gently hit Catra’s shoulder which only sent her toppling to the ground. “Let’s break here for a bit. A little bit of the good blood for you should fix it. Gods, I hope it fixes it!”

The needle barely hurt, the burning of the blood felt more potent. Something wiggled in her mind, nearly blinking open before sealing shut once more.

“Where are we?” She wheezed, going fully limp on the ground.

“Uh,” Scorpia shuffled about, “not sure. Outside, I can see the sky. Let’s just wait here for better light, yeah? A little camp out.”

Catra was too exhausted to fight her. *Then sleep. Oh, let this wretched night end!*

She giggled, “You are so dramatic.” *I am not!* Melog pouted, curled up tightly in her chest, retreating behind her ribs. *I am not.*

Scorpia laughed nervously. “Am I? I mean- yeah, uh, sounds good? Like a plan.”

Catra watched the sky change, unable to sleep but unable to move. Darker and darker, then finally a finger of purple pink light. Barely a whisper, growing in a rosy haze.The early morning light was weak, too weak for human eyes, but more than enough for theirs. Scorpia snored and grunted as she slept through it. A rising sun in Etheria, proof of their survival. Yes, they could wait here, just wait until the day properly broke. Beasts would retreat and they could sneak back home. Forget Plumeria, forget the supplies, forget… everything.

Forget. Forgotten? Her heart raced. *Something is here.* Melog sounded fuzzy, sleepy, distant. She whispered into the dark, “What do you mean?” Their confusion bled into her. *You know it. You’ve seen it.* “Seen what? Melog, what- what have I seen?”

Their silence was deafening.

Catra slowly sat up, surveying their spot for the first time. A wide and rolling courtyard, bordered with cliffs, some dropping off towards the distant shores, some towering tall over them, one half destroyed. No, no, that was a wall. A wall with a door. To where? No way to reach it from here. From this side. Where… *Ah, I see. Closed your eyes, she closed them one by one.* She couldn't fathom what that could mean.

Arcane magic sparked from the courtyard. *There,* Melog purred the sound rattling loudly from her own chest. It sparked again. Catra could smell smoke and metal and something else. Her eyes strained, her ears twitched. Curiosity coiled in her gut until the tension was unbearable. She crawled towards it, silent on all fours. It sparked again. Around a small hill covered in some sort of dense grass. It sparked again and again. What was it? Melog was silent.

Then the creature growled.

Its skeletal legs jerked and drew in, the massive beast unfolding to tower high above her, as tall as some of the Horde's towers as something electric gathered in its chest. Scorpia jerked awake behind her with a yelp and it detonated with a boom she more felt in her chest than heard with her ears.

Human-like hands and feet pressed into the ground to lift the shaggy beast fully onto all fours, a withered skull as tall as she was swung up as it shrieked at her intrusion.

Her father had laughed once, when she'd gone to him scared of the terrifying hunter that prowled near their home, he'd told her something. It had scared her worse, but later it had soothed her. His teeth had glinted under the sunlight, as he smiled at her, sweeping her up into a tight hug.

Her first memory was the only memory she had of her parents. A memory at the gates of the orphanage-

“What’s wrong with me?” The words tumbled unbidden and drew the beast’s full attention.

It whirled faster than she’d expected, sending her jumping back as it howled at them. They were little more than two small beasts trapped inside with it. The doors were too heavy and strong to open fast enough. The wall across from them had crumbled, too tall to scale from this side. Her parents had fled to the orphanage on the night of the hunt. The beast crawled towards them, creeping forward slowly as more and more sparks flew from its pelt. Its face was not quite human, it reminded her so much of-

“Catra, run!” Scorpia darted one way, and on instinct alone Catra hobbled the other way. It followed her with rotten breath, and inside of its empty ribcage Catra saw something small glint and shimmer like a jewel. It called to her. Sang to her so sweetly. Its jaw cracked open too wide and too close.

Scorpia grabbed it in both her claws, gripping with all her might. The beast spun, kicking and screaming, before discharging again. Scorpia rolled backwards and away, further and further. “Yeah that’s right, come on big guy, let’s go! This way! Catra!? Melog!? Someone over there okay? Hey now!” She dashed in and out as it swiped at her, sparks trailing behind its razor sharp claws. It snapped at her, jumping and shaking the ground as it pursued her. An ill timed dodge left Scorpia flattened to the ground, writhing for a moment with pain.

Catra blinked from underneath its body, whip flying to cut at desiccated tendons and bones as thick as her body. She didn’t know how she got there, but as it slammed itself into the ground, barely missing her, she saw the glinting again.

Her body ached from the night before, it took effort to dart in for a few hits, just enough to distract it from Scorpia and allow her to heal. If it could nearly down her partner with a single swipe, Catra had no delusions of what it could do to her. Its screams became louder, more pained, more infuriated and nothing seemed to work. Right until Scorpia managed to grab its back leg a second time,

once again gripping with all her might. Last time it almost shook her off. This time it howled as the bone broke in her claws.

The beast dropped to the ground, the sparks blew out fully; the air was free of arcane magic.

Scorpia twisted and wrenched and pulled with all her might to break the leg further.

And Catra ran to its skull, stared into its empty eye sockets and pushed just enough. Her hand grew and twisted as she slammed it through the side of its skull. For a moment she saw Weaver's broken skull, the smoke jerking and fragments flying as she smashed it as hard as possible with the bulky trick sword.

Then she drags her hand back to break the skull further, wider; bone fragments cut as they flew past her face. There was no smoke this time. Only a warning of lights too blue to be real.

Catra stumbled backwards as it started to rise, half its face missing, the sparks growing and pulling hard enough to suck her in towards it. There was no way to escape the pull before the next detonation, but it never came. Instead the beast dropped again, sparks crackling out as Scorpia punched and swung at its other back leg. The shine. The glint. Catra dropped her weapon to run on all fours, jumping and twisting to land squarely inside its massive ribcage. Scorpia was screaming something, the beast was shrieking back, the wind howled in her ears as the charge began to build again.

She'd once been used to the feeling of electricity. The bolt paper pressed against her skin or the burn of the blood as it healed her. The way Weaver smiled thinly at her whimpering at the start, the inevitable scowl when she cried. The source of its power crackled across her skin like lightning but it didn't hurt this time. Her hand closed around a glimmering badge, cold metal and colder magic. The beast howled and collapsed again, throwing Catra around inside of it as she tried to pull the thing free despite the growing glow of magic. Scorpia's claws slammed between the ribs, pulling

hard enough to break them clean off. She ripped with all her strength at the same moment it finally detonated -

Catra woke on the ground by the door, sitting up slowly in the early morning light to stare out at the courtyard. For one moment a cold terror swept through her, irrationally fearing she had died and was now doomed to die to the creature again. Instead, it lay shattered where it had fallen. The skull twisted as if looking at her, its fur limp, its bones fractured and scattered. She patted absentminded at her pocket, now empty of all the vials she'd held. Scorpia slept, covered in drying blood, sweat, and dust between Catra and the door as if to guard her.

The badge she'd fought so hard to get, to rescue, lay broken in fragments. Tossed aside like trash.

It hurt us. Melog grumbled, far and quiet. *So she made sure it would not do so again.*

The thread she had captured slipped between her fingers. The memories receded leaving her head to ache. And as Catra stared at Scropia she considered Melog's reminder.

Kill her. You could do it right now. She is too weak to fight you, the healing was all for you. Kill her, drink her blood. Grow stronger with it.

She bit her own fingers until they bled between her teeth to satisfy the need.

It didn't help.

Rage: Beastly Hunters

Chapter Summary

> Were you not a hunter once? Is this sincerely what you want?
>
> ...
>
> You can't go on like this... I pity you. A hunter gone mad for the hunt...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra had never expected to feel sympathy for Shadow Weaver in death, not with the rage that boiled under her skin. But that fire, that lightning- it's gone. She's carved out and hollow. It leaves a space for things to crawl in, thoughts she doesn't want. But, the madness of having known, the madness of things beyond human reach, she can understand Weaver much better now.

The badge fragments sit in her pocket. Inert. Worthless. Warped beyond what it was but never more than that either. Scorpia had inspected it closely but didn't recognize it, only begged Catra to throw it aside, that it was evil in some way.

The irony isn't lost on her. Neither are the parallels.

If there was anywhere left to buy drink, Catra would fall deep into the blood. She craved it in ways she can't describe. Desired it for far more mundane reasons.

When she was little, Weaver would sometimes share her precious blood. It was far too strong to give a child straight, but every so often when her mood was lifted she would give Catra a single sip from her flask. It had made her warm, made her feel like syrup before drifting into sleep. No cares. No worries. No pain.

She's seen the research hall, the experiments done there. She's seen the hunt fully now, beasts large and small. She's seen the desperation, the desolation, the destitution. She has gained insight of some kind into their world, more than most could stand. It's more than she can stand, but stand it she must.

She rolled the gem, or was it glass? Dark blue but translucent enough. Cracks spiraled in its center. It sat inert between her fingers, but something still tingled in her hand at the contact.

Oh yes. She understood Minister Weaver much better now.

Things are as they were once more. Scorpia cheerful and kind and smothering. The hunt unending. Their death's inevitable by violence or starvation. Catra thinks often of the first turned hunter she'd ever seen, the way the woman had howled and sobbed, begged for help and mercy. She'd called it a curse. This feels like a curse to her, to be so close to so many things and denied them all categorically. All is as it was, and if she could let go of the knowing then perhaps she could go back too. To blank but hopeful still, to something with a purpose and a drive no matter how ruderless. Perhaps in time she'd even learn to be happy.

Catra's unsure that she's ever really been happy before.

She just has to let go of it. She's never wanted to know the secrets of the world, too dark and horrible. She's never wanted the power and responsibility that comes with it.

But it's so close. As if she could reach out and touch it, a word on the tip of her tongue, a glimmer in the corner of her eyes.

Knowing something was there, that it was missing, that she'd never know what it was…

Weaver had spoken rarely of her life, but she had spoken with conviction. Catra had thought it to be lies at the time, an act she put on. Her worship of the old faith done as a pittance and her attendance at church a charade, her concern for Etheria and her people a guise for her own sick and twisted desires. Now Catra

wondered instead what had done her in. Was it the blood, the violence, the terrible nightmare of their existence? She supposed it didn't matter, not truly. But what had made the woman snap?

And if she had broken after enduring so much for so long, what possible hope did Catra have to survive in its wake?

"And here's some soup for you!" Scorpia placed a bowl down carefully. She'd mostly gotten the hang of her new strength, and even of having massive claws, she still broke things on occasion and finding replacements was getting harder. "Sorry it's not that much, we'll find something soon though. Maybe over by the witch's village, oh what's it called, the, ah dang it." Scorpia hemmed and hawed as she thought and Catra watched her almost sightlessly.

"Oh, you wish to be a hunter do you?" Weaver had said the words so sweetly to Adora, but filled with grave concern. They dripped with poison as she spoke them to Catra now. "Monsters in the making, idiots to boot, but I can send you over now if that's what you wish. You can join the other children."

Catra had never seen one of the others after they left for the Horde. Those who escaped to the streets she had seen a few, the rest had vanished as if they never existed at all. If Minister Weaver had promised she'd join the Horde as a hunter, Catra might cautiously believe her. But the only promise was to join those who had vanished, and she did prefer to live.

She turned her attention to her own thin and meager meal. Her stomach turned and the stone rolled between her fingers. She reached for Melog and found little more than a bubbling pit of blood and bone. Where had they gone? Her lips trembled, the panic rose, she pushed it down to mechanically eat. Melog had grown quieter and more contented with Scorpia, but where were they? She could feel them, they were there, they were just so quiet. She didn't know how to live with the silence in her head anymore, and Scorpia's rambling no longer filled the voids.

Her throat hurt as she spoke, “Hemwick.”

“Hemwick, yes, thank you!” Scorpia smiled broadly at her, unmoving long enough for it to grow stale before looking away.

She never asked, so Catra never told.

She hoped the guilt would eat Scorpia alive.

“Fine.” Catra stood, placing the remaining soup down on the floor before grabbing her cane.

“Fine? Uh, wait what are you-” Scorpia also jumped up fumbling to leave her empty bowl on the chair. “It’s almost morning.”

“Doesn’t matter.”

It didn’t. She wasn’t sure the last time she saw a person, a real and regular person. Daylight used to be a death sentence, now it promised to keep them safer than the night could.

“S-sure thing, you are so right!”

Scorpia was a queer sort. Catra couldn’t understand how she’d ended up a hunter with the Horde, she lacked the dedication, she lacked the blood thirst, she lacked conviction in the hunt. She had become a monster and lacked in all the right ways though, so perhaps it had been enough. Scorpia had her faith, of course, the ancient faith of the First Ones, for what little that did. She gave thanks in the old tongue, she sacrificed at the altars she could now that materials were so easily at hand. Coffins had always lined Etheria’s streets, but now there was no one left to protect them and Scorpia’s claws made easy work. Perhaps it was her faith that had tied her to the church, despite their differences.

Perhaps that was what tied Weaver there as well.

Gods it was a mess. It was all such a damn awful mess.

All was too quiet, all was too stale. Catra yearned for something she'd hated just to break the yawning void. She could almost smell the fragrant oils the vicar would use on them as she'd prayed, "Let us partake in communion, and feast upon the old blood. Our thirst satiates us, soothes our fears. Seek the old blood, but beware the frailty of men. Their wills are weak, mind young. The foul beasts will dangle nectar, and lure the meek into the depths. Remain wary of the frailty of men. Were it not for fear, death would go unlamented. Let us pray, let us wish. Seek the old the blood."

"Fear the old blood," Scorpia all but whispered, causing Catra to twitch.

Had she spoken it aloud? She didn't think she had.

"How is she, really?" Scorpia asked, looking towards her with grave concern.

Catra's throat closed up tight, a growl rumbled in her ribs before she managed to choke it down. Melog. She was trying to speak to Melog. Was this how she acted during the times she was gone?

Even without an answer, Scorpia, of course, continued, "I know she's trying, she's a fighter, and she's… she's too good for all this."

Too good. Ha! Catra almost laughed, almost snarled, almost sobbed. No. It couldn't be further from the truth. Weaver had been right after all. Catra was a beast, Adora had been special, Etheria did not deserve its fate, the gods were to be respected and feared, and knowledge would set them free.

She moved faster, jerked as she began to run recklessly. There was no way to answer that and Melog was so very quiet. The world blurred until it all came back into too sharp of focus.

"There!" A man shouted, far too jolly as he pointed at them from a rooftop. "Beastly hunters, both of them."

His companion turned as well, her face unreadable as they quickly leapt down to the street. It was too narrow to flee, and too cramped for a good fight. It was a death trap, and if the hunters had merely done their job properly, they would both already be dead.

Catra glanced at Scorpia before preparing herself. There was no way out now.

Scorpia used to try and reason with the hunters who found them, especially when they looked human like these two. It had been foolish then and was more foolish now. They merely looked human, but Catra knew there were no true humans left. Beasts and hunters, and hunters are more monstrous than the beasts.

"Careful," The woman hissed as her companion leapt down from the roof tops much closer to them than she had.

"I'm always careful, love!"

Catra has never hated a hunter worse than she does in that moment. It made her blind with rage. The first strong feeling she's had in- she really can't say. When nothing lives inside you, the smallest spark can become an inferno. She let it overflow, her mind going fuzzy with it. "Leave. You are not wanted here!" Her grip tightens on her sword, smacking the tip into the ground to transform it into a whip.

Scorpia glanced at her in confusion, "What are you doing?"

She didn't know. It had felt right to warn them.

But the hunters don't respond, perhaps they've grown numb hearing other half turned creatures scream the same at them. Catra wished they would just listen to it. But instead the man pulled something off his belt and lit it using the lantern hanging from his belt.

They scattered as soon as the bottle left his hand, a molotov was more than enough to end the fight before it began. There's a

ticking sound as he threw something else, hard to see in the darkness of the early morning, Catra yelped as it exploded in another fiery bang. She jumped to the side, off the wall, and turned to charge him. Even managed to slice him across the chest with a good swing, buying just enough room to see the woman fully engaged with Scorpia further down the alley. Good, let her regret her choice once her damned skull caved in!

"Ha!" The man laughed, manic and pleased. Half drunk on blood then, Catra was sure he'd transform soon if they didn't stop him now. Catra growled as the man hurled two more bottles. The caskets and some of the buildings were at risk of catching on fire now. The anger burned alongside the oil.

"Are you stupid!?" She hissed as he dodged her claws. "Or have you got a few screws loose? You'll burn the whole city at this rate!" The man finally hesitated, looking shocked, and Catra took full advantage. Her whip managed to cut deep into the back of his ankle, and he screamed as he collapsed to one knee. "You could have left!" When she gasped, she could smell his blood. The only words for it were crisp and clean. She'd never smelled truly fresh blood. Untainted, damn them both, to have survived so long without the church's cursed healing only to throw it away so foolishly! "Why didn't you leave!?" The words cracked and filled with gravel. Something was wrong with her. Something was terribly wrong with them both.

He stared up at her with an open mouth, stuttering through the pain, "I- ah! My apologies, I- can you understand me?"

She wanted to kill him, but her hands shook with the breaking inside of her. Perhaps her mind, perhaps her heart, she couldn't tell. She couldn't tell and she was so tired, and these hunters made her feel mad. "So, you're just stupid then? Of course I can fucking- what, can you not understand me!?"

"Gods be good," he whispered, then whimpered, "as it so happens, yes I can! Ah! Give me a moment, please, you got me quite good- b-but I'd prefer to talk seeing as you can!"

Her hand ached, Scorpia screamed, distantly she heard bells ring. Catra wasn't even aware of moving forward until the heavy net slammed her to the ground. And then the man was standing, his saber rubbed with fire paper glowed brilliant yellow orange in the night. It made her laugh, barking horrible laughter. How did she keep falling for the same trick? Weaver would talk, Adora would talk, so many hunters and so many beasts- Etheria was no place for such nonsense.

There's no humans left, nothing but flesh hungry beasts are left. It was time she remembered that.

Melgo growled with her, finally waking and shredding through the net, arm swinging to catch the man on the backswing of her whip- only for Scorpia to grab and haul her backwards.

"Wait! Wait, we don't want to fight, please!"

So, her too then. Melog's skeletal muzzle seemed to stretch and smile. *Yes!* All talk, no action, and now she'd think to turn against them. *Yes, yes!*

Scorpia's grip loosened after she quickly stepped backwards, "We- we're not like the rest, full faculties you see." Almost pleading. It was pathetic.

It turned out that the anger had never gone away. Banked, but not put out.

From the moment she woke in the Healing Horde's halls, it has never once gone away. Moments where it lessened, moments where it faded when her fear was greater, but never far away. She'd lost it and so lost herself as well, lost all that mattered. Catra would never let it go again. *Let it sing to us, we want it, we need it.* It boiled over in her veins, made her blood feel too thick for her heart to pump. She was not allowed to know, she was not allowed peace, she was not allowed happiness- she need not concern herself with it then. She need not care about any of it.

Catra could feel that this won't be enough. Even if she killed all three, ate of their flesh, drank of their blood, it would not be enough. It's not the right time. Not yet. She needed to calm down, she needed to pick her moment right. Melog purrs with amusement. Catra can't hear the conversation anymore, she managed to wiggle free to stagger away, gasp for air, try to calm down. *Peace, breathe, come down.* Her claws squealed as she slowly closed her hand against the glass of whatever shop this had once been. She couldn't recognize herself in the reflection, the little beast never felt like her. She could hear Scorpia's heavy footfalls and growled deeply, choked on her own words. Melog spoke for them, more awake and alert for having rested.

" *Do not touch us.* "

"Okay, Wildcat, got you loud and clear buddy."

"Is it turning?"

"She- it- they are NOT turning, please, there's, she's unwell. She needs treatment, that's all!"

Like she's not even here. Like she's lesser than them. *Show them. "Show them all."*

"Yeah, what kind, because I'm just saying I have a bullet-"

"Dearest, please don't joke like that!"

"Touch her and I'll kill you."

Always feigned affection, all to control her. But she needed that didn't she? Stupid little beasty, a firm hand was required, they all knew it. Everyone knew it. " *The sweet blood, it sings to us."* She can't breathe deeply now, gasping for air again. Catra was fully out of control now, but she hadn't blanked, little more than a puppet to Melog's whims. Their roles reversed, was this how they felt? Or could they even feel like her at all?

"That doesn't sound like needing a little help, beast."

“My name is Scorpia, and that’s just- it’s just how Melog is. They’ve never acted on it though, Catra keeps it in check. Just- just give her a little space.”

She laughed at that. Never acted on it. Ha! She punched at the wall and her fist went through glass, she’d forgotten the window, how much has she forgotten? She punched again, could feel a large shard of glass slide under the skin of her hand, cold fire washed over her knuckles as it sank deeply. The metal bars warped under her fingers, bending as she squeezed. She yowled, the sound deep and scratching and whinging and warning. Her damned head! Was this what Weaver had felt? Was she finally chosen? It was too much and too little, like her insides might explode from her body.

And then something touched her shoulder, gingerly, carefully.

Foolishly.

Catra blinked.

And watched as the two hunters dragged Scorpia’s body around a tight corner at the far end of the alley. Fire burned too hot for her to follow between them, the blood trail shined too large and bright for her to ignore. Her jaw hurt, her lips stuck together as she gasped for air. Her hands- gods, her hands were drenched in too dark blood. “Oh gods, oh gods, save me!” Her shirt was ripped, blood stained fully down its front, darkened the top of her pants. She trembled even as she felt more invigorated, more awake than she had in far too long.

The rage was gone, and with it came true clarity.

Melog’s purr petered out in uneven bursts as they curled behind her ribs. *I told you the blood was good. I told you it would help!*

The cane whip dropped from her numb fingers. “What did you do?”

What did we do?

What had she done? She didn't know. She could r-remember.

"S-scorpia." Catra called far too soft as the flames crackled higher around her, catching every building with any wood or cloth attached left. She heard, faintly the way her partner screamed. She'd weakened her, made her too weak to fight back again the hunters who would- they would- "Scorpia!" She pushed too close, howled as the flames licked at her. "SCORPIA!?"

She sobbed, she sobbed as soon as she opened her mouth. Dangerous. She was too dangerous now. Too far gone. Arms wrapped around herself, Catra stumbled backwards blindly finding her way to the main road. It was so cold now, the drying blood, without the flames there to warm her. "S-so cold."

She laughed. She sobbed and she laughed and was lost until she recognized the opening. A cellar that grew into a cave. Access to the underground. The catacombs and the labyrinth.

A hunter of hunters and their blade of mercy.

She didn't deserve it, but she'd rarely deserved much. They'd said they were fond of her, once, long ago. Perhaps they would be fond enough to finish her.

She'd forgotten. With Scorpia there, she'd forgotten what she was. No true hunter. Catra prayed to Sh'ra as she descended that Double Trouble wouldn't let such a small thing stop them. And if they weren't down here, well it would be well enough then wouldn't it?

Weaver had been right. She belonged down here in the dark and the depths. To never return, to never see the sky again. Whatever happened to her now was only what she had earned. Too broken to be of use, too beastly to pretend anymore. She was tired. She was so tired and Weaver had been right all along.

Torches flickered as she made her way on shaking legs, Melog's presence faltering against her will.

She couldn’t remember. So it was best for her to forget, to be forgotten.

Really. It was.

Chapter End Notes

To avoid another confusion here, don't worry too much about Scorpia, she's lucky. For now.

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